gives rewards for the best suggestions. "There is a sheet, a pen and a pad in the auto, with five questions for me to understand my customers' opinion of my services. All you have to do is tick the boxes and write your email address. I select the best feedback and give them a prize of Rs 1,000 out of my income," says Annadurai enthusiastically.

So, who is this uniquely pleasant individual? "My hometown is Rettavayal village near Peravurani, in Thanjavur district," says Annadurai. "My dad, Ganesan, is a culinary expert. My mother, Amsavalli, is a housewife. My family came to Chennai 38 years ago—that was when my dad started driving an auto. I have studied till 12th standard. My parents supported me well with my education, but I wanted something else. It has been 12 years since I started driving my dad's auto," he sums up his history simply. How did he come up with the idea of being different? Annadurai smiles. "I sincerely love this career. I thought it would be nice to put in some utilities and facilities for customers who travel in my auto. I want to make their trip a pleasant one." Being tech-savvy, Annadurai also started accepting payments via credit and debit cards well before cashless transactions became popular.

His innovative way of functioning has taken him right to the top. He has given talks at conferences held by the likes of Google and Microsoft, and was also invited to attend a meeting in Delhi in 2020, attended by Prime Minister Narendra Modi and several Union ministers. Annadurai's different style of operating arises from his understanding of passengers' expectations. "All they want is a sense of security and respect [on their journey]. Our appearance is also important. I shave daily and stay clean. I always wear my uniform when attending to my passengers," he explains.

Apart from customer-centric innovations, Annadurai also offers altruistic services—for example, offering free rides to teachers, doctors, cleaners and nurses. He doesn't take payment from children and women travelling on Children's Day and Women's Day, respectively, and does not charge extra for the amenities in his vehicle, only the fee fixed by the government. "Everyone has a money problem, but isn't it wrong to think of taking money from another's pocket? I do not focus on money. Customers will come back if we are true to our business with integrity." ■

Happiness Quest: *A joint enterprise of India Today and the RPG Group celebrating exemplary initiatives to spread happiness*

COLOUR ME *Happy*

The right shade can elevate your mood and bring positivity and serenity to your home

By **RIDHI KALE**

From pastels to millennial pinks and from fuchsia to teal, the hue you pick can not only determine the look of your home but also have a huge impact on your mood. Here's what the experts say.



SEEING RED?

"Red is often associated with boldness and a sense of power. The colour is also believed to carry good luck and warmth into a living space," says Suparna Handa, managing director at Sarita Handa, a luxury and lifestyle brand. "It stimulates passion and sensitivity." Use this hue on cushions or bedspreads to add a pop of colour and brightness to your space.

TWO TONES BETTER THAN ONE

"In this doom-and-gloom environment, everyone craves positivity. Here, colour plays an important role—it is one of the easiest ways to get positivity into your home," says Nikita Bansal, head of lighting design at Orange Tree. She says a combination of white and blue can do the trick. "White is the synthesis of all colours, which symbolises neutrality, purity and cleanliness. Blue is all about serenity and calmness. It reduces tension and stress." This combination works very well for ambient lighting, where the play of light and shadow brings added drama.

SAY HELLO TO YELLOW

When selecting colours, think about the vibe you want. "Yellow is like sunshine. It relates to joy, optimism and energy. Whether gold, mustard, lemon or canary yellow, the hue is unmistakably vibrant," says Avani Juneja, co-founder and creative director of Beyond Dreams, a furnishings studio. Playful shades are perfect for children's bedrooms and nurseries; deep tones make a kitchen come to life. "Life gets a little sunny with a ray of yellow as upholstery accents in a dark room. Statement furniture and accessories make for beautiful styling," says Juneja.

LET THE WALLS SHINE

"Vibrant hues and floral motifs can create positive energy in living spaces," says Neha Jain, co-founder of UDC Homes, a company that specialises in wallpapers. "The most refreshing colours are blue and green. The influence they have on wallpaper design is stunning." Green is a symbol of freshness, prosperity and nature. "Incorporating nature-inspired themes on wallpaper designs in different shades of green has a calming effect on the mind. On the other hand, blue symbolises wisdom and serenity, and when used on the walls, this colour can create great harmony."